

Discrimination Harassment and Violence Prevention Policy

Policy Summary & Knowledge Check

Authority	Chief Operating Officer
Date Ratified	January 13, 2026
Next Review Date	December 2026 (annually)
Previous Amendments	December 6, 2024; February 2, 2024; October 11, 2023; and earlier
Review Committee(s)	Board of Directors

Policy Summary

This policy reflects the USC's commitment to providing a workplace free of discrimination, harassment, and violence for hired, elected, and volunteer positions, and for those who interact with them, including the public. It defines key terms such as discrimination, harassment, sexual harassment, poisoned environment, workplace violence, and domestic violence, assigns administration to the Senior Manager, People and Development, and sets out the USC's, Members', and Managers'/Supervisors' expectations and responsibilities — including a duty to investigate incidents even when no formal complaint has been made.

Key Takeaways

- Applies to all USC employees and Members, including hired, elected, and volunteer positions and USC Club Executives/members, and covers harassment from any source, including the public.
- Not intended to apply to general student-to-student or student-to-University contact within Western University.
- Prohibited grounds of discrimination include race, ancestry, place of origin, colour, ethnic origin, citizenship, creed, sex (including gender identity), age, marital/same-sex partnership status, record of offences, sexual orientation, family status, and handicap.
- Harassment includes repeated or serious unwelcome behaviour or comments, including virtual communication incidents, but does not include reasonable performance management or workplace direction.
- Workplace violence includes physical or indirect threats, abusive calls, weapons on property, property sabotage, stalking, restraining order violations, and threatening acts or language; domestic violence in the workplace is also addressed.
- The Senior Manager, People and Development administers the policy; the COO steps in if that role is conflicted, and the President/Board become involved if the COO is the Respondent.
- The USC must investigate reports or incidents of harassment, discrimination, or violence even if no formal complaint has been made, and must undertake a workplace violence risk assessment.
- Members must report incidents to their Manager/Supervisor immediately and complete an Injury/Illness Reporting Form; emergencies go to Campus Police at 911 or ext. 83300.
- Members must not ignore threatening or violent behaviour and must follow up or escalate incidents even when no formal complaint is filed.

Knowledge Check

7 situational questions to check understanding of this policy. An answer key follows on the next page.

Q1. An employee overhears a coworker repeatedly making unwelcome comments about another colleague's ethnic origin. What does this policy expect of the employee who overheard it?

- A.** To report it to their Manager/Supervisor and not willfully ignore a poisoned environment.
- B.** To wait and see if the targeted coworker files a complaint first.
- C.** To handle it informally themselves and not report it further.
- D.** Nothing, since they weren't the target of the comments.

Q2. A Member witnesses an immediate, escalating threat of violence in the workplace right now. What is the correct first step?

- A.** Document the incident and raise it at the next staff meeting.
- B.** Contact Campus Police at 911 (or ext. 83300) immediately, given the immediate danger.
- C.** Wait until the person involved calms down before reporting.
- D.** Email the Senior Manager, People and Development and wait for a reply.

Q3. Does this policy apply to general student-to-student conduct within Western University?

- A.** Only if a USC Member is also directly involved.
- B.** Yes, in all circumstances.
- C.** No — it is not intended to apply to general student-to-student or student-to-University contact.
- D.** Only during Orientation Week.

Q4. An anonymous but credible report suggests harassment may be occurring, though no formal complaint has been filed. What is the USC's obligation?

- A.** The matter can only be raised by the alleged victim.
- B.** The report must be dismissed as unverifiable.
- C.** No action is required without a formal, signed complaint.
- D.** The USC shall investigate reports or incidents of harassment, discrimination, or violence even without a formal complaint.

Q5. Who administers this policy if the Senior Manager, People and Development is personally conflicted, such as being named in a complaint?

- A.** The Chief Operating Officer.
- B.** Any available Board member.
- C.** The chair of the Human Resources Committee.
- D.** The complainant's direct supervisor.

Q6. Which of the following best matches the policy's definition of a "poisoned environment"?

- A.** A single minor disagreement between coworkers.
- B.** A workplace where harassment or discrimination is so severe or frequent it creates an intimidating or hostile environment affecting work or academic performance.
- C.** Any workplace experiencing high stress or workload.
- D.** A workplace with inadequate physical facilities.

Q7. A Member wants to know whether this policy's definition of harassment covers messages sent by text or instant message rather than in person. Is virtual conduct covered?

- A.** Only if the recipient forwards it to a supervisor within 24 hours.
- B.** No, only in-person conduct is covered.
- C.** Yes — the definition of harassment specifically includes virtual communication incidents.
- D.** Only if the message is sent during scheduled work hours.

Answer Key

Q1: A — Sections 5.2.5 and 5.2.8 require Members not to willfully ignore a poisoned environment and to report incidents of discrimination or harassment to their Manager/Supervisor.

Q2: B — Section 5.2.9 directs individuals to contact Campus Police at 911 or ext. 83300 in the event of an emergency or threat of violence.

Q3: C — Section 1.3 states the Policy is not intended to be applied to general student-to-student or student-to-University contact within Western University.

Q4: D — Section 4.3 states the USC shall investigate reports or incidents of harassment, discrimination, or violence even if no formal complaint has been made.

Q5: A — Section 3.1 states the Chief Operating Officer shall be responsible for administering the Policy if the Senior Manager, People and Development is involved in a complaint.

Q6: B — Section 2.4 defines a poisoned environment as one where harassment or discrimination is so severe or frequent that it creates an intimidating or hostile environment.

Q7: C — Section 2.2 states harassment includes virtual communication incidents.